Deception, fate & gender

Question appearances

1 Fair and foul

Duncan: trusts the welcome

Audience: knows the plot

Unequal knowledge → tension

Witches join opposites in 1.1, unsettling certainty. Lady Macbeth separates an "innocent flower" from a hidden "serpent" (1.5).

Duncan trusts the castle's welcome while the audience knows the murder plan: dramatic irony.

2 Private thought, public mask

Asides and soliloquies let us hear what Macbeth conceals. At the banquet, his reactions undermine the image of a secure king.

Ask who knows what at each moment and how that changes audience tension.

Weigh responsibility

3 Predictions are equivocal

Macbeth hears safety in promises with unexpected meanings. Branch-carrying soldiers make Birnam Wood seem to move.

Macduff's unusual birth defeats Macbeth's interpretation of "woman born".

Partial truth encourages false certainty.

4 Choice remains visible

Witches tempt, but Macbeth plans and acts. Banquo hears prophecy too and responds more cautiously.

Dagger vision can show intention and fear. The ghost may suggest guilt, supernatural punishment or both.

Support an interpretation with stage action and language.

Compare courage

5 Competing ideas of manhood

Lady Macbeth links courage to murder. Macbeth initially insists on moral limits to manhood.

He later questions the murderers' masculinity, repeating her tactic.

Macduff insists grief is human and compatible with courage.

6 Avoid simple labels

Lady Macbeth's influence changes; she does not control every later crime. Banquo is cautious, but interested in his future.

Historical beliefs can illuminate kingship, witchcraft and gender; audiences need not respond identically.

Distinguish Scotland in the story from Shakespeare's stage audience.